about football, but our senses were always tuned and our muscles were always taut, awaiting that alarm.

The alarm itself was a phone. Red, plain, no buttons, no dial, just a base and handset. Its ringer was antique, consummately British. *Brrrang.* The sound was vaguely familiar; I couldn't place it at first. Eventually I realized. It was exactly like Granny's phone at Sandringham on her big desk, in the huge sitting room where she took calls between games of bridge.

There were always four of us in the VHR tent. Two flight crews of two men each, a pilot and a gunner. I was a gunner and my pilot was Dave—tall, lanky, built like a long-distance marathoner, which in fact he was. He had short dark hair and an epic desert tan.

More glaringly, he possessed a deeply enigmatic sense of humor. Several times a day I'd ask myself: Is Dave serious? Is he being sarcastic? I could never tell. It's going to take me a while to solve this guy, I'd think. But I never did.

Upon hearing the red phone ring, three of us would drop everything, bolt for the Apache, while the fourth would answer the phone and gather details of the op from a voice at the other end. Was it a medevac? (Medical evacuation.) A TIC? (Troops in contact.) If the latter, how far were the troops, how quickly could we get to them?

Once inside the Apache we'd fire up the air-con, strap on harnesses and body armor. I'd click on one of the four radios, get more details on the mission, punch the GPS coordinates into the onboard computer. The first time you ever start an Apache, going through preflight checks takes one hour, if not more. After a few weeks at Bastion, Dave and I had it down to eight minutes. And it still felt like an eternity.

We were always heavy. Brimming with fuel, bristling with a full complement of missiles, plus enough 30-mm rounds to turn a concrete apartment building into Swiss cheese—you could feel all that *stuff* holding you down, tying you to Earth. My first-ever mission, a TIC, I *resented* the feeling, the contrast between our urgency and Earth's gravity.

I remember clearing Bastion's sandbag walls with inches to spare, not flinching, not giving that wall a second thought. There was work to do, lives